

Chapter 36-1: Heartless Person

This competition ended in such a chaotic situation. The twenty-eight disciples who had struggled out of the illusion were helped up from the ground by their respective sects and taken back. The white-bearded old man announced Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's victory and respectfully delivered the sacred water to the sect leader's table.

He also apologized to the various sects who didn't know what had happened, saying that tonight they would prepare unique delicacies and fine wines from Zhaoyang Mountain to entertain everyone, asking them to rest well and gather their strength for tomorrow's Zhaoyang Conference.

So the place dispersed in chaos. The sect leaders were personally led back to the Peach Blossom Garden by the white-bearded old man to rest, while the other disciples also scattered like birds and beasts, chattering as they went down the mountain.

Ning Fuyi walked back toward Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, encountering countless gazes along the way - some probing, some disdainful, and some envious. She paid no attention to any of them.

"Fuyi, you must be tired. Go back and rest quickly." Before other elders could open their mouths to question her, Elder Yuanming spoke with a smile, handing her the sacred water contained in a jade bottle. "Here, this is yours."

"Thank you, Elder Yuanming." Ning Fuyi accepted the sacred water, smiled at him, then nodded to the other elders before stepping past them and mixing in with the disciples.

"Yiyi, come quickly." Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin waved urgently to call her over. Ning Fuyi ran over in a few steps. Along the way, some disciples stopped her with curiosity, but she deflected them all with the excuse that she was feeling unwell after just coming out of the illusion, dodging and weaving back to her friends' side.

"Let's go back first." Rong Jin pulled her down from the high platform, avoiding the curious fellow disciples. The three walked very quickly, and in no time had left the others far behind, walking down the white jade steps of Zhaoyang Mountain.

Ning Fuyi's thoughts kept returning to the scenes from the illusion, so she was distracted the whole way until Liu Wenzhu slapped her shoulder, finally bringing her back to her senses.

"Yiyi, when did you become so close with the Divine Venerable? I thought the one called in would be either me or Senior Brother Rong Jin. How did it turn out to be the Divine Venerable?" Liu Wenzhu's cherry lips were pressed together, her words gentle but somewhat aggrieved.

Just as Ning Fuyi didn't know how to explain, Rong Jin spoke up to help: "I guess it's like the elders said - that Nightmare Beast had a problem."

"Alright then." Liu Wenzhu pouted. "So what happened between you two inside?"

"It just brought people into their most painful and most precious memories. It's just small tricks, not difficult to resolve." Ning Fuyi laughed carelessly. Rong Jin and Liu Wenzhu beside her exchanged glances and tacitly didn't ask further.

Painful memories - they didn't need to think to know what that meant. Liu Wenzhu felt pity and held Ning Fuyi's hand even tighter.

The three were slowly walking down the steps when chaotic footsteps came from behind. Several Eastern Garden disciples led by Feng Ge came down the steps. The three stepped aside to make way for them, but when Feng Ge walked in front of them, she let out a disdainful snort.

In the blink of an eye, the group was just a bunch of backs. Liu Wenzhu frowned as she watched, saying indignantly: "I can't understand what this is about. Usually Senior Sister Feng Ge is very nice, but when it comes to Yiyi, she seems like a different person."

Rong Jin shrugged, while Ning Fuyi remained calm.

"They just think I used dirty tricks to beat Li Chaoan, that my victory was dishonorable. Plus, I actually summoned the Divine Venerable, so they think I only know how to climb relationships and go through back doors. They look down on me." Ning Fuyi continued walking as she spoke.

"Then I'll explain to them." Liu Wenzhu frowned. "We're fellow disciples. We can't let them wrongly accuse you like this."

"People can only see what they want to see. Whatever they think I am, that's what I am. Opening my mouth to explain will only make them believe it more firmly. If everyone thinks I'm evil, then no matter what I do, I'll be evil." Ning Fuyi smiled. "So I'll go my own way, regardless of what they think."

"Aren't you coming?" Ning Fuyi saw that Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin hadn't followed her, turned back and tilted her head at them, then strode away with large steps, layers of sleeves swirling, her hair swaying boldly left and right.

Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin exchanged glances, both seeing confusion in each other's eyes.

"Is this still the same Ning Fuyi who used to love crying?" Rong Jin said.

"I don't know." Liu Wenzhu shook her head, but her gaze followed that figure in a daze. "But she seems much better this way."

After returning to her room, a small immortal attendant delivered spring water drawn from Zhaoyang Mountain's divine spring to each room for the disciples to bathe in. It was said that this spring water had the effect of washing away internal and external impurities, detoxifying and calming the mind. Ning Fuyi poured it into the bathtub and undressed to bathe.

She had secretly snuck over to look near Shenyu¹ earlier and found that for some reason, the forbidden area that had no guards yesterday was now surrounded by layers of barriers. Even the azure phoenix that guarded the divine mountain kept circling in the sky, unwilling to leave for a long time.

It seemed that having missed yesterday, trying to secretly break into Shenyu would now be as difficult as ascending to heaven. She lightly flicked the bathtub with her fingertips, thinking about how to get her Emei Thorn.

However, as she thought, her mind suddenly wandered, returning instead to the scenes she had seen in the illusion today. She had never seen Chu Qingqiu like that before - with jade-like skin and bones, tearful eyes full of emotion. Though her coldness and pride remained undiminished, there was also added tenderness.

Her weak and lying appearance contrasted sharply with her power to overturn heaven and earth with a wave of her hand, giving rise to a strange sense of curiosity.

When being held by that black shadow, she showed a softness never revealed to anyone else - soft shoulders, soft waist, and lips that also looked soft...

"Damn it." Ning Fuyi suddenly cursed, her hand loosening as her body immediately slid into the bathtub. The clean water enveloped her entire body, washing away impurities while also washing away the thoughts in her mind.

What was she thinking? That was Chu Qingqiu. Even if she had once been weak, she wasn't now.

It must be that today's unexpected discovery of Chu Qingqiu's secret had shocked her, causing her thoughts to become confused. When her emotions returned to normal, she leaped up from the water, summoned clothes with a wave of her hand, and as she put them on, the water on her body evaporated with her immortal power.

Her clothes were quickly arranged. She turned to sit by the window, staring out at the blooming flowers in a daze.

She wondered when Chu Qingqiu had that experience, and what kind of person could have hurt Chu Qingqiu so much that she turned to cultivate the Path of Emotionlessness. Ning Fuyi sighed and pressed her lips together, suddenly feeling that Chu Qingqiu wasn't as unattainable as before. After all, she had also been an ordinary person and had ordinary human emotions.

As she thought, the scenes from the illusion floated in her mind again. Ning Fuyi frowned and slapped herself hard, forcing herself to forget.

Afterwards, she practiced cultivation until her door was knocked by a small immortal attendant, only then opening her clear eyes and getting up to answer the door.

"Fellow immortal, the Saintess has set up a banquet at Seven Absolutes Hall². Please honor us with your presence," said the red-lipped, white-toothed little immortal attendant in a childish voice. After speaking, he spread his wide sleeves, bowed his head in salute, then left.

Her stomach was indeed empty and rumbling. Ning Fuyi felt her stomach growling, so she agreed and went out. Unable to find Liu Wenzhu, she went to Seven Absolutes Hall by herself.

There were immortal attendants giving directions along the way. She passed through pavilions and glazed palace walls, walking toward a area of rosy light. The sunset at Zhaoyang Mountain appeared extremely magnificent, with colors much richer than elsewhere. The so-called Seven Absolutes Hall was the main hall of Zhaoyang Mountain, rising high through seven-colored auspicious clouds, surrounded by flower trees that bloomed constantly. Standing in front of the hall, one could take in half of the divine mountain.

Along the way, there were disciples from various sects everywhere. Some wore very expensive clothes and looked like they were from famous major sects, while others wore simple cloth clothes, looking around curiously with full of amazement at the grandeur of the divine site.

She mixed in with the crowd and walked into the hall. Although it was outdoors, it was brightly lit, with two rows of night-luminous pearls embedded around the great hall, illuminating the hall like daylight.

The area closest to the inside of the hall was surrounded by immortal mist, with steps made of flowing clear water that, though continuously moving, felt solid when stepped on and wouldn't wet the soles of shoes. Low tables were placed on either side, prepared for the sect leaders and elders. Everyone sat on them and had already begun drinking and chatting.

Ning Fuyi found a secluded corner to sit in. As soon as she sat down, fine wines and delicacies immediately appeared on the table in front of her. The wine was all Divine Immortal Drunk³ brewed from peach blossoms, and the fruits and vegetables were all special items only found in the divine realm. Even the meat was different from what was outside the mountain, smelling of flowers.

After sitting down, Ning Fuyi began eating ravenously, finishing all the food on the table in no time. After she finished eating, the leftover food disappeared, leaving only wine and tea snacks made from fresh flowers.

"What? This year's Zhaoyang Conference wants us to enter Shenyu?" Suddenly, she heard the conversation of two Tianji Sword Sect disciples behind her. Ning Fuyi's heartstrings jumped, and she put down her wine cup.

"You must have heard wrong. Shenyu is the place where ancient war gods fell. The Zhaoyang Saintess has guarded Zhaoyang Mountain for generations and never allows anyone to enter. Even a bird can hardly fly in. How could they choose Shenyu as the location for the final trial?"

"I definitely didn't hear wrong. When I went to deliver tea to the sect leader, I personally heard him say it. What our sect leader says can't be false, right? Shenyu is that kind of place - there must be countless treasures inside. It seems that everyone will spare no effort in this Zhaoyang Conference to get a chance to enter Shenyu."

"Sigh, I already had no hope of achieving any ranking. Now with this, everyone will use all their abilities, so I'll have even less chance of standing out," that disciple said disappointedly.

Ning Fuyi didn't listen to the complaints that followed. She was already immersed in unexpected joy. The final level of the Zhaoyang Conference was actually entering Shenyu? Wasn't this getting what she wanted without any effort!

She originally didn't care about the so-called ranking in the Zhaoyang Conference, but now that she heard this, she would have to use all her abilities to give it a try.

After Ning Fuyi finished thinking, she had also eaten and drunk her fill. She got up and wanted to leave, going back to prepare for tomorrow's Zhaoyang Conference. However, just as she stood up, she caught sight of a white figure from the corner of her eye.

That figure sitting there wasn't hard to notice, not only because she was eye-catching enough herself, but also because of the large area of empty tables around her, as if she had a natural barrier.

It seemed no one dared approach her vicinity. Although it was due to fear, her sitting alone there, contrasted with the lively drinking and chatting around her, still looked somewhat desolate.

Ning Fuyi's steps paused, and she suddenly walked toward her as if possessed by a ghost.

Footnotes:

1. **Shenyu (神陨)** - "Divine Meteor" or "Divine Fall," the forbidden area where ancient war gods fell
2. **Seven Absolutes Hall (七绝殿)** - The main hall of Zhaoyang Mountain, named for its seven distinct features or levels
3. **Divine Immortal Drunk (神仙醉)** - A type of wine brewed from peach blossoms, considered especially intoxicating and divine